Leadership Tool: Building a Support Network and Finding a Mentor

Stepping into a supervisor role for the first time is both exciting and daunting. As a newly hired supervisor, you may feel pressure to prove yourself and navigate unfamiliar challenges – from managing former peers to making high-stakes decisions. It's easy to fall into the trap of thinking you have to "go it alone" and figure everything out by yourself. The truth is, *no new leader succeeds in isolation*. Even the most talented supervisors benefit from having others to lean on for advice, feedback, and encouragement. In fact, leadership experts emphasize that new managers thrive when they intentionally cultivate a strong support system around them.

One of the best moves you can make early in your supervisory career is to build a robust professional network and find a trusted mentor. A support network ensures you have peers and allies to share ideas, vent frustrations, and brainstorm solutions with – a vital outlet since you can't always discuss certain management challenges with your direct reports. Likewise, a good mentor provides guidance from experience, acting as a sounding board and helping you avoid pitfalls. Research shows that new leaders who seek support and mentorship are not only more confident but also more successful over time. For example, a *Harvard Business Review* study found 84% of CEOs with mentors credit that relationship for helping them avoid costly mistakes, and 69% say it improved their decision-making (De Janasz, & Peiperl; 2015). By actively developing your network and mentorship connections, you set yourself up with a safety net – and a springboard – for your growth as a leader.

Why New Supervisors Need Support and Mentorship

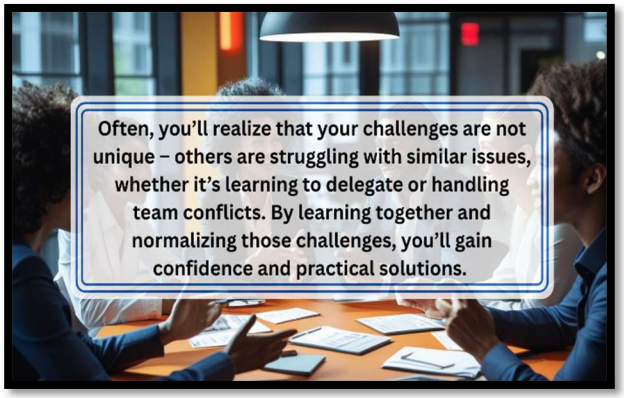
Moving from an individual contributor role into supervision is a challenging transition. Suddenly you're responsible not just for your own work, but for guiding a team. This leap can feel overwhelming and even isolating. It's normal to wonder if you're doing things right. That's where a support network and mentors come in – to reassure and guide you through the learning curve. A strong network and mentorship can dramatically accelerate your development as a supervisor. On the mentorship side, direct access to an experienced perspective – someone who has "been there, done that" and can share insight on the *"ins and outs" of the organization* and what it takes to succeed. A mentor essentially fast-tracks your learning by imparting hard-earned lessons and organizational knowledge that would otherwise take you years of trial-and-error to acquire.

Beyond skill-building, emotional support and confidence are key reasons to invest in these relationships. Leadership can be emotionally taxing; you will face difficult conversations, personnel issues, and high-pressure decisions. During those times, being able to call a peer from

your network or consult your mentor is invaluable. Knowing that others have your back reinforces that you're not alone in the challenges you face. This moral support reduces stress and builds resilience. The message is clear: reaching out for support is not a sign of weakness – it's a smart strategy for success. With the "why" established, let's explore how you can build your network and find a great mentor.

Building Your Support Network as a New Supervisor

1. Proactively Connect with Your Peers: One of the first steps in building your support system is to reach out to other supervisors – especially those who are at a similar stage in their leadership journey. Fellow new managers can relate to what you're going through and offer camaraderie as you all learn the ropes.



- Don't hesitate to introduce yourself to peers in your organization or in your industry. You might start an informal lunch group or chat channel with other new supervisors to swap stories and advice.
- Make it a goal to build positive relationships with other managers instead of seeing them as competition. In the long run, your peers can turn into a valuable brain trust that you can lean on throughout your career.

2. Branch Out Beyond Your Immediate Team: As a new supervisor, it's important to broaden your network both within and outside your organization. It's easy to cling to your old circle of colleagues (especially if you were promoted internally), but don't let that stop you from meeting new people. Take initiative to get to know managers in other departments, higher-level leaders, and professionals in your field.

- Volunteer for cross-functional projects, attend inter-departmental meetings or social events, and simply introduce yourself to colleagues you don't know well.
- Don't be shy about reaching out – most experienced managers remember what it was like to be new, and many will be happy to share advice if you ask.
- Similarly, engage with professional networks outside of work. Consider joining industry associations, online forums, or LinkedIn groups related to your field or to leadership development.
- Set small goals, like reaching out to one new person a week or attending one networking event a month. Over time, these connections will form a web of support around you.

3. Leverage Internal Resources – Including HR and Your Own Boss: Your support system isn't limited to people at your level. Don't overlook internal resources like your HR department or your direct manager as part of your network. HR, in particular, can be an invaluable ally for new supervisors. Great HR professionals aren't just enforcers of rules – they're coaches and

confidants who have seen many managers succeed (and struggle) and can share that institutional wisdom.

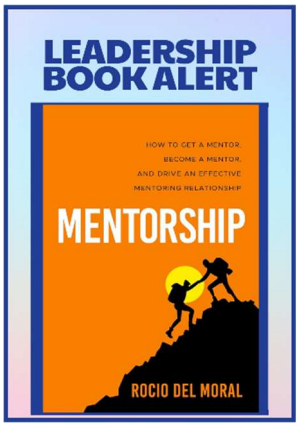
- Build a good relationship with your HR partner
- Your own manager (i.e. the person you report to) is another pillar of your support network. Especially in your early days, schedule regular one-on-ones with them to clarify expectations, seek feedback, and ask for guidance on challenges. A supportive boss can act as a mentor in some respects, or at least connect you to other development opportunities.

4. Create or Join Peer Learning Groups: An effective way to formalize peer support is to create a small group of fellow new supervisors who meet regularly to share and learn together. This could be a monthly roundtable (virtual or in-person) where you discuss leadership topics, or a simple group chat where members pose questions and crowdsource advice.

- To start one, you might ask a couple of fellow supervisors, "Hey, would you be interested in a casual bi-weekly coffee chat where we discuss how things are going for us as new managers?" Even 3-4 people is enough for a rich discussion.
- Some companies have formal new manager cohorts or communities of practice, but you don't need to wait for that – you can initiate a meet-up yourself.
- If you prefer a more structured approach, you can also tap into external leadership workshops or forums where new managers convene. The goal is to embed yourself in a community of leaders who learn and grow together.

Finding (and Benefiting from) a Great Mentor

While building a broad network of peers and supporters is essential, finding a dedicated mentor is equally pivotal for a new supervisor. A mentor is typically a more experienced professional who can take you under their wing, provide one-on-one guidance, and champion your development. Many successful leaders point to a mentor who made a difference early in their careers. So how do you go about finding a mentor, and once you have one, how do you make the most of that relationship? Here are some best practices:



1. Identify What You Need in a Mentor: Start by reflecting on your own strengths and development areas as a supervisor. Where do you feel unsure or want to grow? Perhaps you need to improve your people-management skills, understand the strategic side of the business better, or learn to navigate office politics. Knowing what you want to learn will help you identify the right mentor – someone strong in those areas who has the experience to guide you. Often, the best mentor is someone a few levels ahead of you who has successfully done what you're trying to do (for example, a respected manager in another department, or a former boss who excelled as a leader). Look for a person whose leadership style or career path you admire. It's also

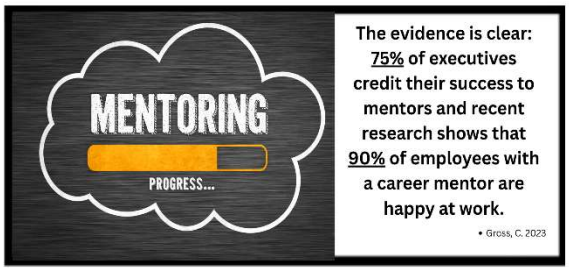
important that you feel comfortable with them – mentorship works best when there's mutual trust and good chemistry. Don't limit yourself to one candidate; you might have a couple of people in mind. If your organization has a formal mentoring program, take advantage of it, but also remember you can initiate a mentorship informally on your own by simply reaching out.

2. Approach Potential Mentors Respectfully and Clearly: Approaching a would-be mentor can be nerve-wracking, but keep in mind that many experienced professionals enjoy helping newcomers. You can start in a low-key way: ask for a brief meeting or coffee chat to seek their advice on a specific topic. By framing it as seeking advice, you flatter them and make the ask manageable.

In that first meeting, come prepared with 2-3 thoughtful questions. Pay attention to the rapport: do they listen well and offer constructive insight? If it goes well, you can express that you found their advice valuable and propose meeting periodically. You don't have to use the word "mentor" right away if it feels awkward – often these relationships start informally. Over time, if the person is receptive and invested in your growth, you've essentially found a mentor.

3. Be an Active Mentee: Once you have a mentor, it's on you to cultivate that relationship. Mentorship is not a passive, one-way street – your engagement and effort as a mentee matter. Schedule regular check-ins (perhaps monthly or bi-monthly) and come to each conversation prepared. For example, you might bring updates on progress since your last talk, new challenges you're grappling with, or questions you've been reflecting on. Being prepared shows your mentor that you value their time and are committed to learning. Also, be open about what kind of help you need – whether it's developing a particular skill, understanding organizational culture, or weighing a tough decision. A good mentor can play many roles: coach, sounding board, challenger, cheerleader, and even connector (opening doors for you).

4. Learn from Your Mentor's Experience – and Mistakes: One of the greatest advantages of having a mentor is being able to learn from their hindsight. As the saying goes, "a smart person learns from their own mistakes, but a wise person learns from others' mistakes." Don't be afraid to ask your mentor about challenges they faced or errors they made in their early management days. Most mentors are surprisingly candid about times they struggled – maybe they waited too long to address a performance issue or initially failed to delegate and burned themselves out.



Similarly, mentors can share "insider" knowledge about your organization's culture and unwritten rules, helping you steer clear of political landmines. Pay close attention to such wisdom. At the same time, observe how your mentor handles situations in real time (if you have the opportunity to see them in action or hear about their current challenges). Their problem-solving approach can inform your own. Over time, you'll find that you've accumulated a toolkit

of leadership practices and principles drawn from your mentor's experience – a huge boost for a new supervisor still forming their leadership identity.

5. Set Expectations and Respect Boundaries: A healthy mentorship is built on mutual respect. At the outset, it can help to discuss expectations with your mentor. For example, agree on how often to meet and the best ways to contact each other (some mentors might prefer emails and scheduled calls, while others are okay with an impromptu text). Clarify that you appreciate their guidance and will always be mindful of their time. Mentoring shouldn't feel like a burden to the mentor; it should feel rewarding. One way to ensure this is to follow through on their advice and show appreciation. Even a quick email saying, "Thank you for that suggestion – I tried it and it worked out well," can make a mentor's day. Also, understand that mentors are not supervisors – they won't *directly* solve your work problems or manage your performance. Their role is to guide and support, but you still own your decisions.

Conclusion

Transitioning into a supervisory role will never be completely easy, but you dramatically improve your odds of success by surrounding yourself with a solid support system. You don't have to navigate the challenges of leadership alone – and you shouldn't. By actively building a network of peers and cultivating one or more mentoring relationships, you create a safety net of wisdom, experience, and encouragement that will catch you when you stumble and cheer you on as you grow. New supervisors who invest in these relationships become more confident and capable leaders, and they often see the results in their teams' performance and their own career progression. Remember that building your support network and finding a mentor is not a one-time task, but an ongoing part of professional life. As you settle into your role, continue to nurture these connections. In time, you'll likely become a mentor and resource for others, perpetuating the cycle of support.

References:

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